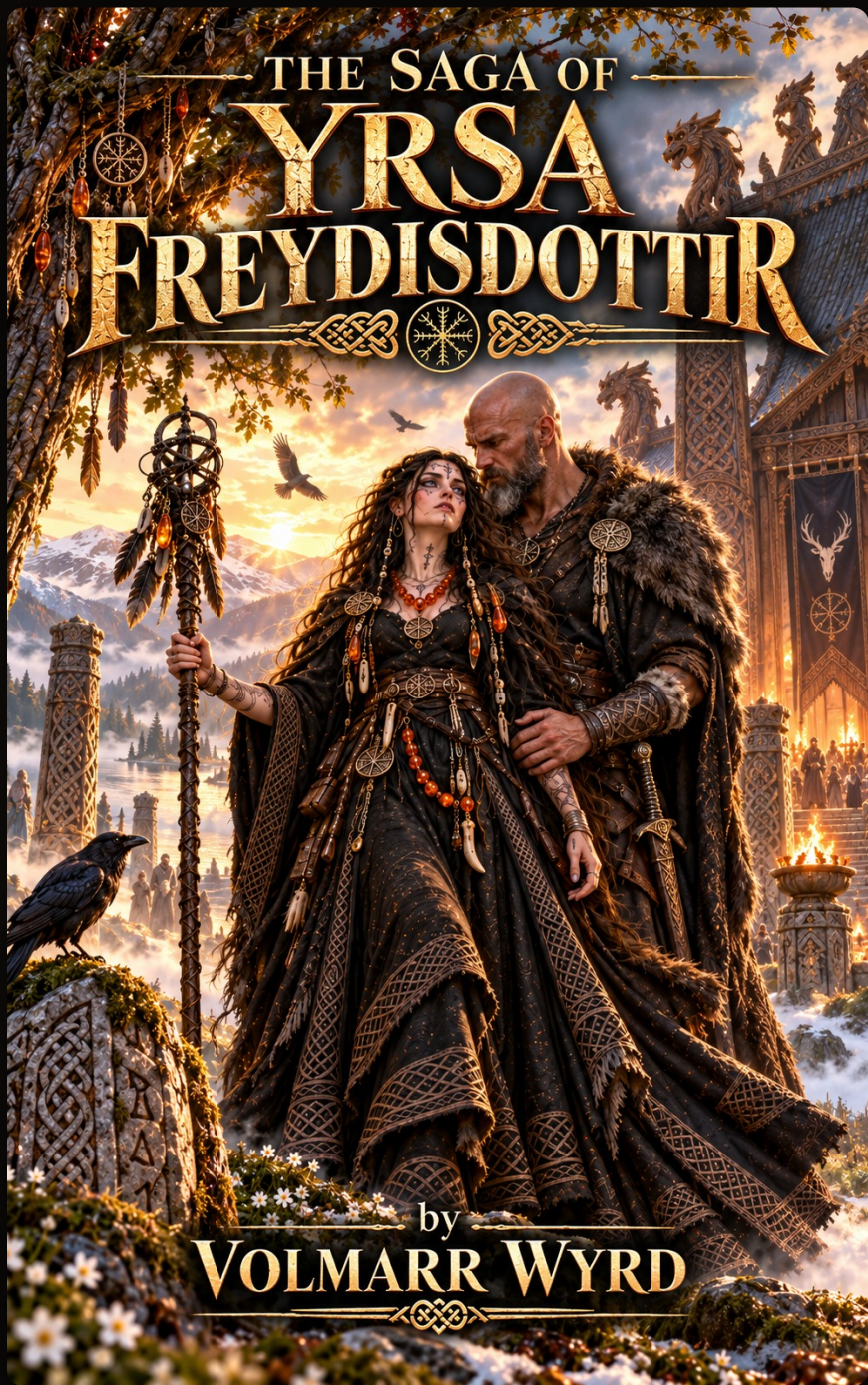




BOOK SAMPLE

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The Saga of Yrsa Freydisdottir

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CHAPTER ONE

THE SEER'S AWAKENING

IN WHICH DESTINY CALLS UPON THE DAUGHTER OF FIRE

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YRSA IN THE CHAMBER OF VISIONS

The smoke of burning mugwort and dried yarrow filled the small timber chamber, curling in lazy spirals toward the thatched roof where dried herbs hung in silent vigil. Yrsa Freydisdottir lay upon the furs, her dark hair spilling like spilled ink across the white pelts, her breath slow and measured as the trance took hold. The fire in the central pit had burned low, casting amber shadows that danced like spirits across the carved wooden pillars.

She had prepared for this moment for three days—fasting, bathing in the sacred spring, inscribing the runes of sight upon her skin with woad and ash. Now, as the sacred herbs did their work, she felt herself falling through layers of consciousness, descending into the space between worlds where the Norns wove their threads and the voices of the ancestors whispered secrets to those brave enough to listen.

In her hand, she clutched the staff her mother had left her—ancient oak, carved with the staves of protection and vision, topped with the sacred wheel that marked her as a seer. It thrummed against her palm with a warmth that spoke of power older than the fjords, older than the mountains that cradled their village in their stony embrace.

The vision came suddenly, as they always did. One moment she was in her chamber, the familiar scents of home anchoring her to the world of the living. The next, she stood upon a windswept plain where the sky burned with colors no mortal eye had witnessed—violet and gold and deep, terrible crimson. Before her rose a hall of black stone, its gates carved with the faces of forgotten gods, and from within came the sound of weeping.

Come, daughter of Freydis, a voice spoke, though no mouth moved to form the words. The threads unravel. The wolf stirs in his chains. You must walk the path of blood and bone, or all you love will be devoured by the dark that rises from the north.

Yrsa tried to speak, to demand answers, but her voice would not obey her. Instead, she felt herself pulled forward, through the gates of black stone, into a hall where shadows moved with purpose and intent. She saw faces she did not recognize—warriors with eyes like winter ice, a king with a crown of twisted iron, and at the center of it all, a figure robed in darkness, reaching out with hands that were not hands but rather the absence of light itself.

And then she saw him. The stranger with the storm-grey eyes and the scar that bisected his left eyebrow. He stood alone on a cliff overlooking a sea of blood, and when he turned to face her, she felt her heart stutter in her chest. Not with fear, though there was plenty of that, but with recognition—a soul-deep certainty that their fates were intertwined, bound together by threads the Norns had spun long before either of them drew breath.

Beware the gift, the voice whispered as the vision began to fade. *For every blessing, a curse. For every victory, a sacrifice. Choose wisely, little seer. The fate of worlds rests upon your choice.*

* * *

Yrsa woke with a gasp, her body drenched in sweat despite the chill of the chamber. The fire had gone out completely, and the only light came from the pale moon filtering through the smoke hole in the roof. Her hand ached from gripping the staff too tightly, and she could still feel the phantom touch of those shadow-hands reaching for her across the veil.

She sat up slowly, her mind racing to make sense of what she had seen. The wolf stirring—that could only mean Fenrir, the great beast bound beneath the earth. But the wolf was a myth, a story told to frighten children into obedience. Wasn't he?

Outside, the wind howled through the pines, and for a moment, it sounded almost like laughter.

Yrsa rose on unsteady legs and moved to the small table where she kept her divination tools—the polished stones, the carved bones, the silver mirror that had belonged to her grandmother's grandmother. She would need to consult them all, to seek clarity in the chaos of the vision. But even as she reached for the stones, she knew what they would tell her.

The time of peace was ending. The age of heroes was beginning.

And she, Yrsa Freydisdottir, seer and daughter of a long line of seers, would stand at the center of the storm—whether she wished it or not.

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END OF SAMPLE

CONTINUE THE SAGA IN THE COMPLETE NOVEL

"THE SAGA OF YRSA FREYDISDOTTIR"

BY VOLMARR WYRD

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